

GitHub Projects: Kanban Board Manual

GitHub Projects is a planning tool built on top of your issues and pull requests. A Kanban board is one view of a project: cards sit in columns by status and move left to right as work progresses. This guide covers the current version of Projects. The old "Projects (classic)" has been retired.

1. Core concepts

Project. A project lives at the user or organization level, not inside one repo, so a single board can track work across many repositories. You can link a project to specific repos so it appears in their Projects tab.

Items. A card on the board is one of three things:

- an **issue**
- a **pull request**
- a **draft issue**, which is a quick note that exists only in the project until you convert it into a real issue

Fields. Every item has fields. The board's columns come from a single-select field, usually the built-in

Status. You can also add custom fields such as Priority, Size, Estimate, dates, or Iteration (sprints).

Views. The same data can be shown as a **Board** (Kanban), a **Table** (spreadsheet), or a **Roadmap** (timeline). Each view has its own filters, grouping, and sorting.

2. Create a Kanban project

1. Go to your profile, or your organization page, and open the **Projects** tab.
 2. Click **New project**.
 3. Pick the **Kanban** template. It comes with Todo / In Progress / Done columns and useful automations. Alternatively, choose **Board** under "Start from scratch."
 4. Name the project and click **Create project**.
 5. Optional: link it to a repository. Open the repo, go to the **Projects** tab, click **Link a project**, and select it.
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3. Set up your columns

The columns are the options of the **Status** field.

- **Add a column:** click + at the far right of the board and name the new status.

- **Rename, reorder, or delete a column:** use the ⋮ menu on the column header. You can also edit the Status field's options under project **Settings → Fields → Status**.
- **Set a WIP limit:** open the column ⋮ menu, choose **Set limit**, and enter a number. The count turns red when the column exceeds the limit. This is the heart of real Kanban practice.
- **Add a description:** also in the column menu. It's a good place to state the "definition of done" for that stage.

A column setup that works well for most teams:

Backlog → Ready → In progress → In review → Done

4. Add items to the board

From the board: click **+ Add item** at the bottom of a column, then do one of the following:

- Type a title and press Enter to create a **draft issue**.
- Type #, pick a repository, then pick an existing issue or PR.
- Paste the URL of an issue or PR.

From a repository: in the repo's Issues list, select several issues with the checkboxes, click **Projects**, and choose your project to add them in bulk.

From an issue or PR page: in the right sidebar, click **Projects** and select the project.

Convert a draft into a real issue: open the draft card, click **Convert to issue**, and choose a repo.

5. Work with cards

- **Move a card:** drag it to another column. This updates its Status.
- **Open a card:** click it to open a side panel where you can edit fields, assignees, labels, and milestone, and read or comment on the issue without leaving the board.
- **Reorder cards within a column:** drag up or down to set priority.
- **Archive finished cards:** use the card's ⋮ menu and choose **Archive**. Archived items are hidden but recoverable from ⋮ → **Archived items**.

6. Add custom fields

Go to **Settings → Fields → + New field**, or click **+** on the header row of a table view. Field types include:

Type	Example use
Single select	Priority (P0/P1/P2), Size (S/M/L), Team
Text	Notes, owner email
Number	Story points, estimate hours
Date	Due date, start date
Iteration	2-week sprints with automatic start/end dates

To show field values on cards, open the **view menu** (▼ next to the view name), choose **Fields**, and toggle the fields you want visible.

7. Customize the board view

Open the ▼ menu next to the view tab name to find these settings:

- **Column by:** choose which single-select or iteration field defines the columns. For example, switch from Status to Iteration to get a sprint board.
- **Group by:** creates horizontal **swimlanes**, such as one lane per assignee, priority, or repo.
- **Sort by:** order cards within columns.
- **Field sum:** shows the total of a number field per column, such as total story points in "In progress."
- **Duplicate view / New view:** create several saved views, such as "My work," "Bugs only," or "Current sprint."

Changes are unsaved until you click **Save** (the view tab shows a dot when it has unsaved edits).

Filter syntax

Type into the filter bar at the top of a view:

assignee:@me	my items
status:"In progress"	one column
-status:Done	exclude done
label:bug priority:P0	combine conditions (AND)
label:bug,enhancement	either label (OR)
is:issue is:open	only open issues
iteration:@current	current sprint
repo:owner/repo-name	one repository

no:assignee

unassigned items

8. Automate with workflows

Open ... (top right) → **Workflows**. The built-in workflows include:

Workflow	What it does
Item added to project	Sets Status (e.g. to <i>Backlog</i>) automatically
Item closed	Moves the card to <i>Done</i>
Pull request merged	Moves the card to <i>Done</i>
Item reopened	Moves the card back to <i>In progress</i>
Auto-archive items	Archives items matching a filter, e.g. <code>is:closed updated:<@today-2w</code>
Auto-add to project	Adds new issues/PRs from a repo that match a filter, e.g. <code>is:issue label:bug</code>

Toggle a workflow on, edit its target value, and save.

Tip: write `Closes #42` in a PR description. When the PR merges, issue #42 closes and the "Item closed" workflow moves its card to Done automatically.

For more advanced automation, use **GitHub Actions** together with the **Projects GraphQL API**. For example, you can set a field whenever a label is added.

9. Track progress with Insights

Click **Insights** (the chart icon at the top). The default burn-up chart shows completed versus open items over time. You can create new charts, such as a bar chart of items per Status grouped by assignee, to spot bottlenecks.

10. Access and sharing

Under ... → **Settings**:

- **Visibility:** Public or Private.
- **Manage access:** invite collaborators or teams with Read, Write, or Admin roles.
- **README and short description:** explain the board's purpose and column rules for newcomers.
- **Make a template (org projects):** save your board setup so teams can reuse it.

Note that a user can see an issue on the board only if they also have access to its repository.

11. Best practices

1. **Keep WIP limits low.** Finishing work beats starting work.
2. **Pull, don't push.** People take cards from *Ready* when they have capacity.
3. **One card = one deliverable.** Split anything bigger than a few days of work, using sub-issues if needed.
4. **Let automation move cards to Done.** Closing an issue or merging a PR should update the board on its own.
5. **Make personal views.** For example, an `assignee:@me -status:Done` view gives each person a focused board.
6. **Review weekly.** Groom the Backlog, check Insights, and archive old items.

Quick keyboard shortcuts

Key	Action
Ctrl/Cmd + K	Command palette
Ctrl/Cmd + F	Focus filter bar
Enter	Open selected card
Space	Select card
Arrow keys	Move selection